

Divyakriti Singh: Need to earmark priority sports to produce Olympic champions from Rajasthan



At *Sportstar Sports Conclave — Focus Rajasthan*, Divyakriti Singh Rathore, a gold medallist in the Dressage Team event at the 2023 Asian Games, highlighted the need for more corporate and government support to improve equestrian infrastructure in India. The panel discussion, titled 'Project Gold - Producing Medal Winners from Rajasthan', was moderated by *Sportstar* assistant editor Jonathan Selvaraj.

"Rajasthan has the history, but India lacks the infrastructure needed to compete with top equestrian nations. In terms of weather, climate, coaching, and equipment, we are not yet on par. I began riding in India during school, but when I chose to pursue it professionally, I had to move to Europe in 2020 and have been there for four years. My ultimate aim is to do it from India," Divyakriti said.

She acknowledged the sport's growth in India, highlighting Madhya Pradesh's proactive approach. "In the last three years, the sport has grown exponentially. Around 100 horses are imported annually, and riding schools, associations, and clubs have emerged. It's an expensive sport and needs corporate and government backing. Madhya Pradesh's model, where they send riders and acquire horses abroad, is exemplary. They've already sent six riders to Europe for the 2028 Olympics — a great example to learn from," she added.

Divyakriti urged the state to earmark 'priority' sports in order to produce Olympic champions. "Rajasthan has a rich equestrian history. The last gold medal before

(L-R) Divyakriti Singh, Divyansh Panwar, Rajat Chauhan, Shagun Chaudhary, and Ripu Daman Singh share their views with *Sportstar* assistant editor Jonathan Selvaraj.

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ours was 41 years ago. In the past decade, over 15 riders from Rajasthan have medalled at the Asian Games, with many Arjuna Awardees. The sports policy exists, but we need to identify priority sports like shooting, archery, athletics, and equestrian. With the right support, we can move forward," she stated.

Shagun Chowdhary, the first Indian Olympian in clay pigeon shooting, pointed out that investment must go beyond infrastructure and focus on coaching quality. "Rajasthan has invested in infrastructure but lags in sports science and conditioning. A poor coach can instil bad habits that are hard to unlearn. Investment in good coaching is vital," she noted.

Para coach and Dronacharya Awardee Ripu Daman Singh stressed the need for infrastructure in smaller towns.

"Governments make promises, but real progress needs committed athletes and

coaches. Even from my small hostel, we produced Arjuna, Khel Ratna, Padma Shri, and Padma Bhushan awardees," he said, urging more comprehensive support.

Archery world champion Rajat Chauhan and Asian Games gold medallist Divyansh Singh Panwar also highlighted the importance of grassroots engagement, the role of coaches, and family support in an athlete's journey.

